STORY

Pharaoh in danger

What a day! Ouni's visit to the Pharaoh's palace turns into a disaster!
But the boy also makes a terrible discovery... the Pharaoh is in danger! Ouni must try and save him!

Page 3



COMICS



ZAK JINKS

Even Zak has homework to do during the holidays!

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GAMES

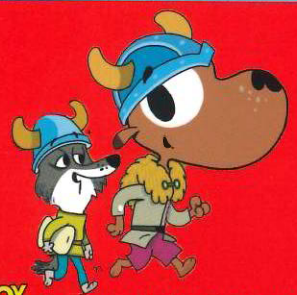


3, 2, 1... Let's get moving!

Exercise is good for our muscles and our brain, so let's get moving!

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AND...



SUPER WOOF AND FLEA INVESTIGATE

Who stole Lazy Albanese's fur collar?

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ADVENTURE BOX was great! Now I am ready for... AdventureBox MAX!

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PHARAOH IN DANGER



Chapter 1

Excitement at the palace

My name is Ouni, and at the time of this story, I was nine years old. That day, my class was going to the palace to meet the pharaoh's scribe*. I don't know what thrilled me more – the thought of listening to the great scribe, one of the most important men in Egypt, or going inside the home of Sokar, our pharaoh. I am usually quite calm, but that morning I was so excited that I knocked over my milk twice in a row and put my sandals on the wrong way round!

I wanted to be a scribe too, one day. I had been learning to write and count for two years, as well as studying the history and laws of my country.

*Scribes used to write official texts in Ancient Egypt.

When we arrived at the main entrance to the palace, Paser, our teacher, said again,

"I don't want to hear a sound. If the royal scribe speaks to you, you lower your eyes before replying. Is that clear?"

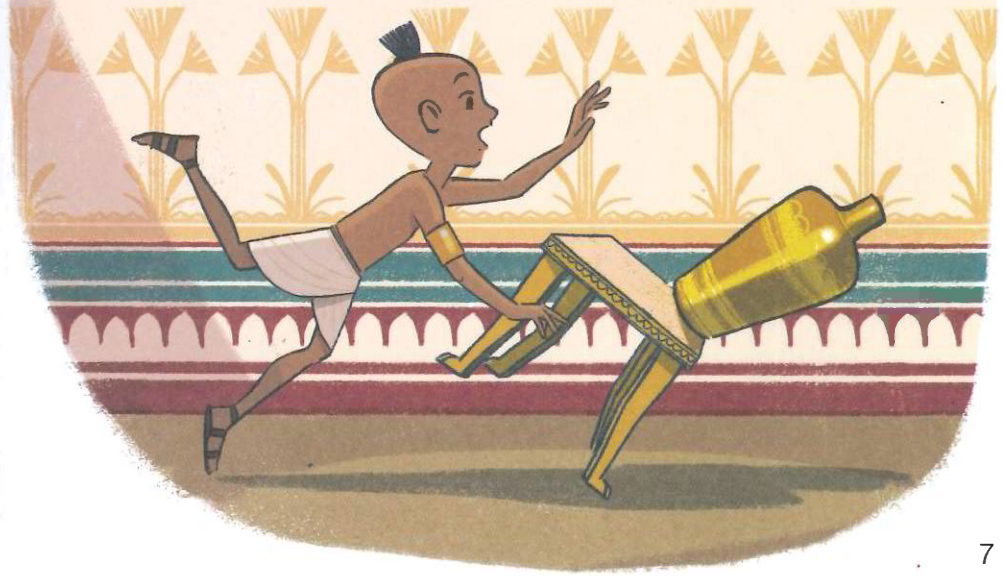
Eight voices chorused,

"Yes, Teacher."





Once we were inside the palace, I was fascinated by everything. I stared at the walls decorated with colourful fish and the birds painted on the ceilings. I was so busy looking up at a painting of a kingfisher that I bumped into a table. The gold vase on the table began to wobble. I tried to catch it, but I lost my balance. Ooops! I fell. The table toppled over and the vase bounced onto the floor, making a loud noise!



As I lay on the floor, I looked up and saw a man hurrying towards me. I could see he was annoyed. He was wearing a lot of gold jewellery as well as the nemes, the headdress that the pharaohs wore. I was gobsmacked... It couldn't be!

I didn't dare move. Pharaoh Sokar roared in a commanding voice,

"Is it you making all that noise in my palace?"

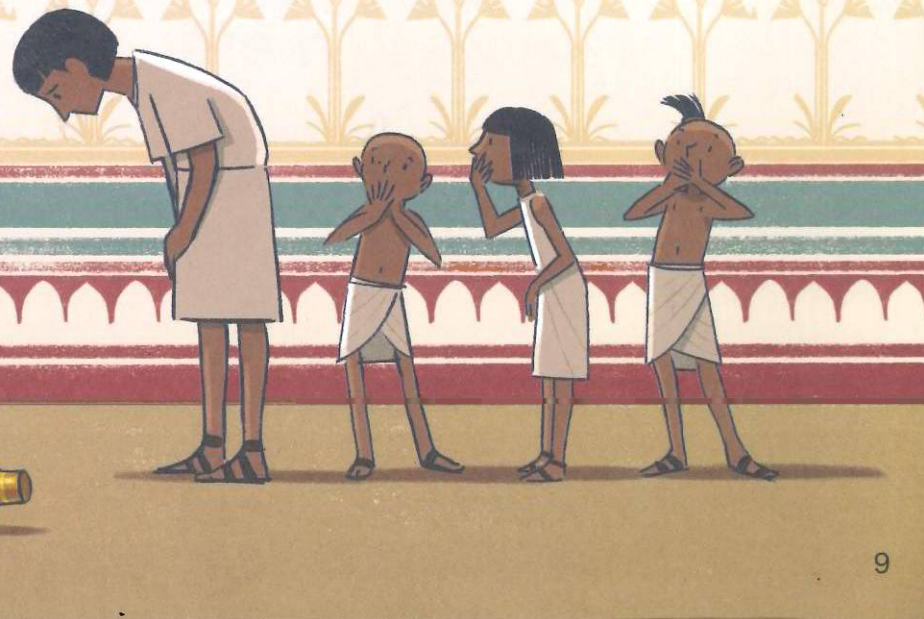


I opened my mouth like a fish out of water, but no sound came out. I felt like I couldn't breathe and would probably faint... My teacher also panicked because nobody was allowed to speak to the pharaoh without his permission! But Paser had to apologise for my behaviour. With his head bowed, he stammered,

"Er... Er... Your..."

My teacher's embarrassment did not improve the pharaoh's mood. He said,

"I haven't got all day! Just tell me what you are all doing in my house!"



My teacher carried on bravely,

"Your Majesty, I do apologise. These children are my pupils, and we have come to meet your scribe."

Then Paser said to Pharaoh Sokar,

"I promise to teach clumsy Ouni a lesson he will never forget."

I was worried about the punishment my teacher was planning for me, but my worry turned to terror when the pharaoh replied,

"I will punish him myself. You go and join the royal scribe. He will be waiting for you."



Disaster! On a visit to the palace with his class, Ouni knocks over a gold vase... and he finds himself face-to-face with the pharaoh who is cross!

Chapter 2



Honey from the high priest

I was alone with Pharaoh Sokar. I bowed my head in respect. I wondered if he could see that my legs and arms were shaking. What was going to happen to me? Was I going to be tickled for hours with an ostrich feather? Or worse, would I have to write out the seven hundred hieroglyphs of the Egyptian alphabet?

Sokar stared at me. Then after a while, he beckoned to a servant and said,

"Take this child to the palace doctor. He is injured."

I looked at my knee. I had not realised it was bleeding.

Then the pharaoh said to me in a serious voice,

"Goodbye Ouni. I hope I don't hear any more about you!"



I couldn't get over it. The pharaoh, the son of the god Amun, had spoken to me! He said my name, and instead of punishing me, he ordered his servant to take me to the palace doctor! I stood up to go, but as soon as I started to walk, everything around me began to spin.

When Sokar saw how weak I was, he said to his servant,

"Go to the kitchen before seeing the doctor."





The pharaoh watched me, half-irritated, half-amused. Then he called,

"I seem to remember promising your teacher that I would punish you..."

I suddenly felt scared again. I thought he had forgotten. Sokar continued,

"My brother, the high priest of the temple of the god Amun, has given me some excellent honey to make sweets for the Opet festival* that takes place in two days."

*The Opet festival was an important religious procession, celebrated every year.

I was terrified. I imagined being covered in honey and thrown into the middle of a swarm of bees. The pharaoh said to his servant,

"Give him some honey! After all this excitement, the child needs energy. A little honey will do him good."

Then Sokar walked away. Was I dreaming, or did the pharaoh smile at me as he left?



The pharaoh does not punish Ouni. Instead, he sends him to the kitchen for some honey as the boy is feeling weak...

Chapter 3



Strange cook

The servant took me to the kitchen. It was huge and filled with amphorae and sacks. There were herbs hung up to dry. It smelt really good! In the middle of the room, a small woman was hard at work. The servant explained to me,

"That is the head cook. Her name is Samut. She is preparing some delicious fish."

When the servant delivered the pharaoh's message to the cook, she grumbled,

"I don't know where the honey is kept. The boy can have dates."



The servant was not happy.

"But the pharaoh said to give him honey!"

Samut replied in a sharp voice,

"I don't have time to look for it!"

Just then, a child my age appeared. She was an apprentice cook. She said,

"I can go and look if you want."

The cook glared at the little girl and shouted,

"Tia, why are you getting involved? Get out of here!"

The little girl ran away, looking scared.

Samut shook her finger at the servant and shouted,

"I make the decisions here!"

But the young servant insisted, clearly fed up with the cook's attitude.

"No, in Egypt, it's the pharaoh who gives orders, and his will is sacred. What makes you think that your word is more valid than his? If you don't obey, you will be dismissed."



Samut realised she had no choice, so she led us to the store room, muttering,

"You asked for it..."

Strangely, the cook immediately found a large pot full of honey. She spread a few drops on a slice of bread.



It was the first time in my life I had tasted honey. There was only a little on the bread, but it tasted so sweet! Then the servant took me to the palace doctor who looked after my knee.

When I got back to my teacher and the other pupils, I was so quiet that Paser thought I had been severely punished... and I did not tell him any different. So he was kind to me.

That evening, when I got home, I was still in a dream world. What a day!



But that night, I did not feel well. I vomited so much that my mother went to fetch our neighbour, who was a doctor. He examined me and asked,

"What did he eat?"

"Some honey and bread," replied my mother.

The doctor said,

"I think he may have eaten something bad."

As he left, he said to me,

"Be patient. If you are still unwell in the morning, I will come back and see you."

My stomach gurgled and was painful most of the night. As I could not sleep, I tried to work out what had happened to me. Suddenly, I thought about Samut, the cook. Why had she lied when she said she didn't know where the honey was? Why did she only give me a few drops? Samut had behaved as if she didn't want me to taste the honey. Then I had a crazy idea... what if it was the honey that had made me ill? What if it had gone off, or worse, what if it was poisoned, and the cook knew about it?



A servant forces the cook to give Ouni some honey. That night, the boy is very sick. Can it be because of the honey?

Chapter 4



An ally

The next morning, I felt better. I was lucky because the Opet festival was starting the next day. It was the year's biggest ceremony. The statue of the god Amun would be carried by priests from the temple at Karnak to the temple at Luxor, three kilometres away. Like all the scribes in town, my teacher was helping to organise the festival, instead of teaching us.

Dozens of boats docked at the port. Usually, I liked to watch their sails on the Nile, but that day, I had other things on my mind. I had to find a way to test the pharaoh's honey. But how would I get inside the palace? I was pacing around outside the building when suddenly, Tia, the young apprentice cook, came out. Without thinking, I walked over to her and said,

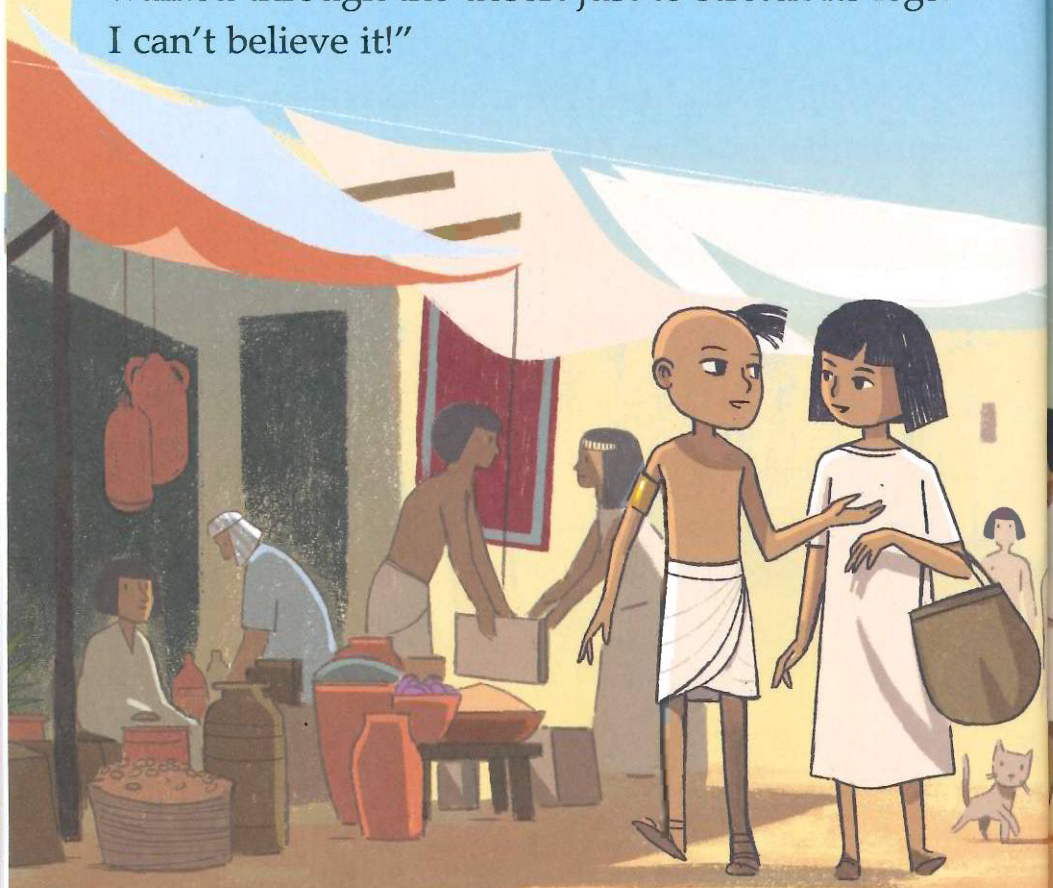
"Hello! I'm Ouni. We met yesterday. Do you remember me?"

"Of course, but I don't have time to talk, I'm on my way to the market," she said.



I asked if I could go with her. On the way, I told her that I had vomited all night long, and I wondered if it was the honey. At first, she made fun of me. She said,

"You think you were poisoned at the palace? That's like saying the Sphinx statue got up and walked through the desert just to stretch its legs. I can't believe it!"



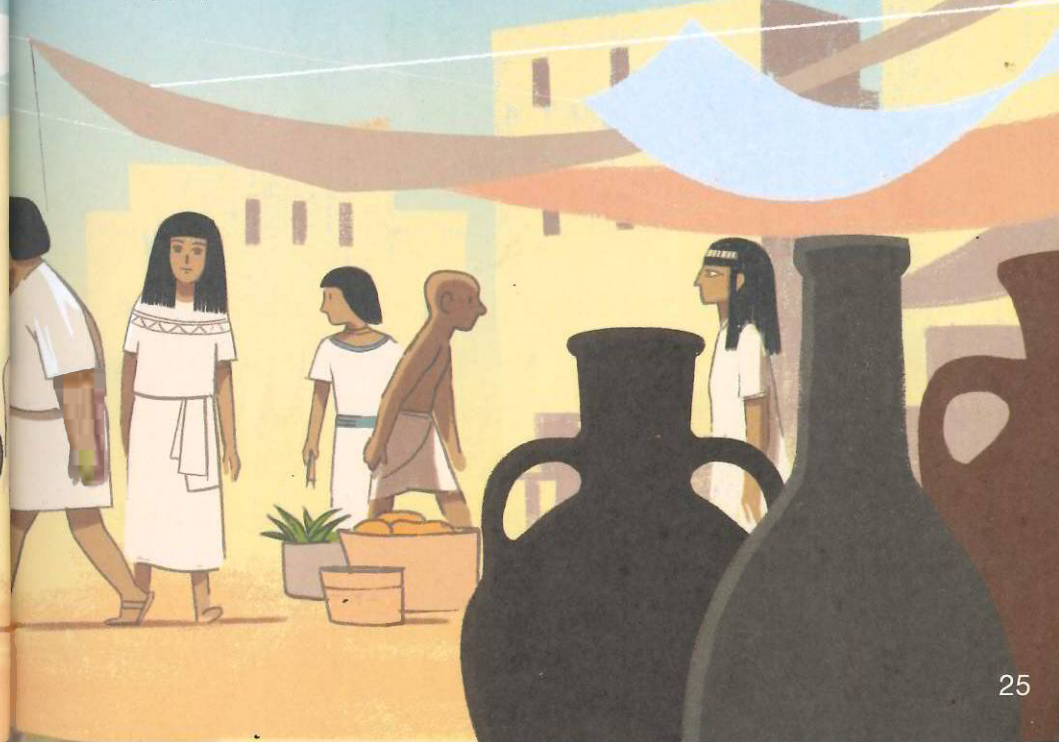
But when I told her about the cook's strange attitude, Tia replied,

"It's true, Samut has been acting strangely recently..."

So I continued,

"That's why I have to take some of that honey and test it."

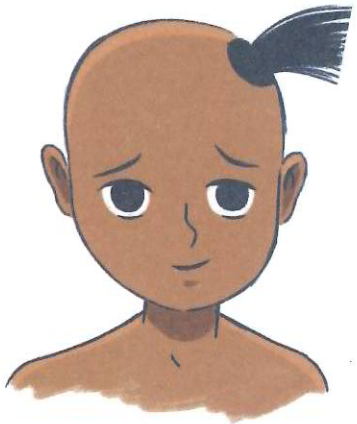
"Impossible!" said Tia. "Samut put it in her personal store room, where she keeps unusual ingredients. She is the only one who can go in there."



Then I said,

"So Samut is hiding the honey? That is proof that I am right! If it's too risky for you, just let me into the kitchen."

Tia hesitated... so I looked at her with my puppy-dog eyes. My mum always said they made me irresistible.



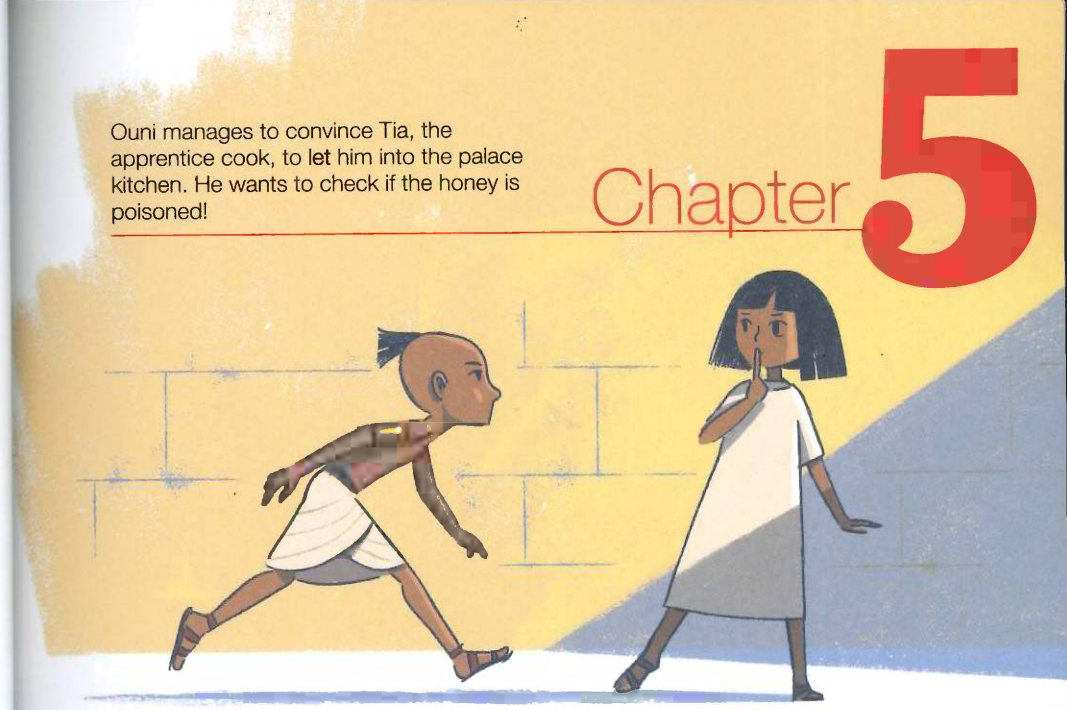
A miracle... it worked! Tia sighed and said to me,

"Ok. Meet me tomorrow morning at five by the back door of the palace."

I hoped Tia would come. I had no choice, I had to trust her.

Ouni manages to convince Tia, the apprentice cook, to let him into the palace kitchen. He wants to check if the honey is poisoned!

Chapter 5



Awful discovery

The next day, I left my house before dawn and met Tia behind the palace at the time we agreed. I had to be quick. The festival was starting that afternoon! Without a word, my new friend signalled to me to follow her. We walked down the silent corridors. At last, Tia pointed to a door and whispered,

"That is Samut's store room."

We went inside, but suddenly, we heard a noise: someone was coming. We just had time to hide before the cook appeared in the doorway of the store room. She was holding a pot of honey! She called to her apprentices,

"Bring me some semolina so I can make cakes for the Opet festival."

There was no answer. Samut was annoyed. She put down the pot and walked away, muttering,

"Where are those lazy apprentices?"



I was about to take a sample of the honey, but Samut was already back. I began to panic... Fortunately, Tia was there. She leapt out of the store room, stood in front of the cook and said,

"There you are at last!"

I was amazed... Tia was so courageous. Samut looked at her and grunted,

"What are you doing here?"



The apprentice replied bravely,

"I heard a noise. I went into the kitchen and you'll never guess..."

"What?" said the cook in an impatient voice.

Tia went on,

"They were everywhere..."

"What was everywhere?" said Samut crossly.

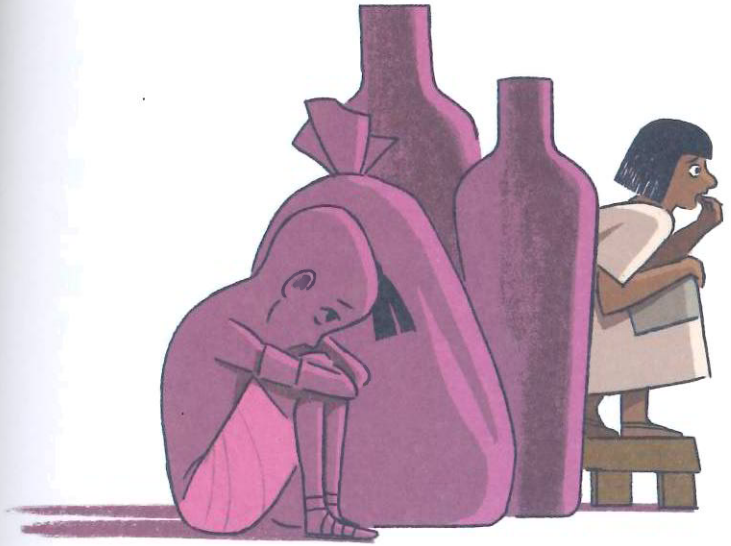
"Rats, of course!" cried Tia.

When Samut heard the word "rats", she yelled,

"Amun, have pity on me, I hate those horrible creatures!"

She was terrified. She ran into the store room and locked herself inside... with me!





I hid behind a sack of grain and was looking for a way out when I heard the door open suddenly. A man said to the cook,

"Get to work!"

Samut groaned and replied,

"I... I can't, your greatness, I am scared of rats."

I could hear the fear in her voice. I wondered whether she was more afraid of the rats or the man who had just joined us in the store room!

The man banged his fist on the table and growled,

"Carry on making the poisoned cakes! You heard the voice of our god Amun coming out of his statue. He gave you a sacred mission. And you are letting some simple rats stop you? The pharaoh must die today, or you will feel the anger of Amun."

Samut mumbled,

"Yes, Master."

I was right. The honey had been poisoned.

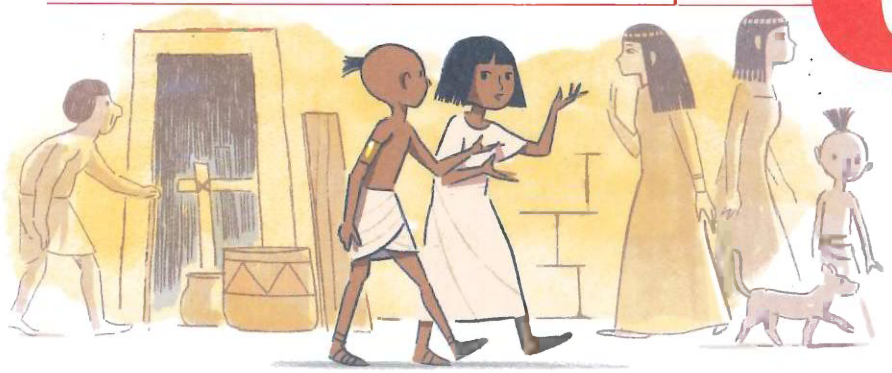


The man who was terrorising Samut was probably the one who came up with the plan to kill the pharaoh. I had to find out who he was. I was shaking as I raised my head slightly. I spotted his shaved head and a precious bracelet sparkling on his wrist as he walked out of the store room. Samut followed him, and in her panic, she forgot to shut the door behind her.



Ouni hides in the store room and hears a man ordering the cook to make poisoned cakes that will kill the pharaoh!

Chapter 6



The chase

When the man and the cook had left, Tia guided me out of the palace. Once we were out on the street, I told her what I had heard. My new friend said,

"Nonsense. The gods only talk to pharaohs. And why would Amun want to kill our pharaoh, who is also a god?"

I didn't understand any of it either. I said,

"We must find out who the leader of the plot is."

No sooner had I finished my sentence than a voice boomed behind us,

"Out of my way!"

A man pushed us roughly. I felt angry and was about to say something, but then I froze. I whispered to Tia,

"That's him! The man with the shaved head! Let's follow him..."



Ten minutes later, the man walked into the Karnak temple grounds. He turned right, then left and walked around a huge statue with a double-feather crown, the symbol of the god Amun. Then... he disappeared! I couldn't believe it.

"He can't have flown away!"

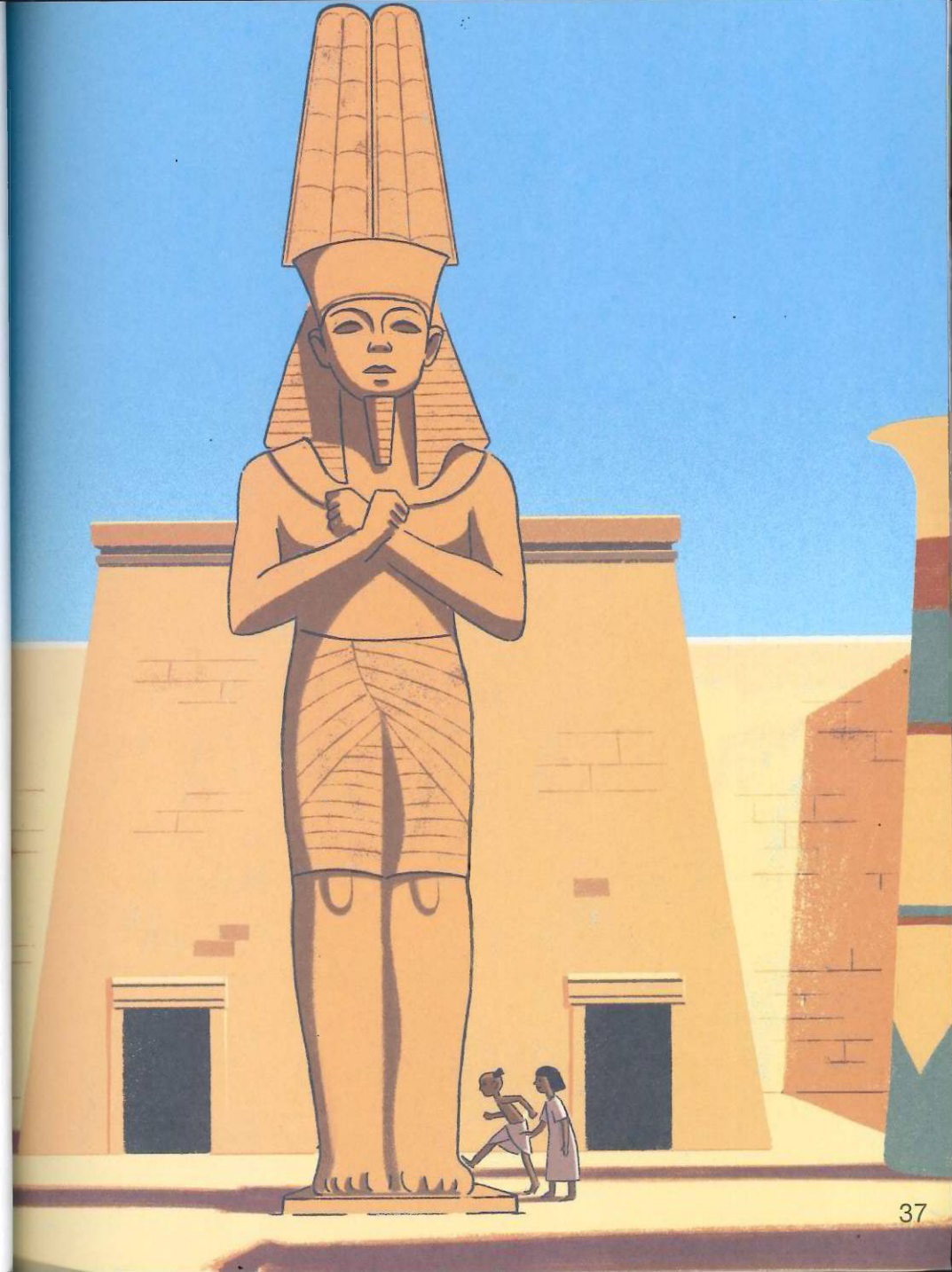
I looked, but I couldn't see anyone. I was furious. I kicked the statue. Ouch! I hurt my foot! But Tia said to me,

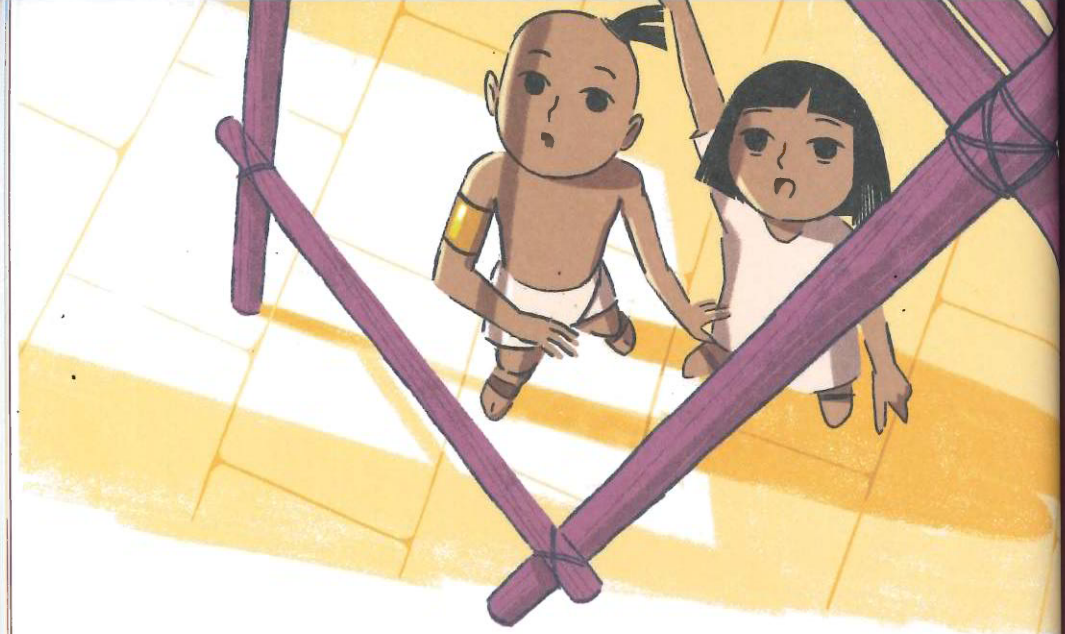
"Do it again!"

I thought that was a strange suggestion, but I had learned to trust her, so I did as she said. Amazing... the statue sounded hollow, as if it was empty! We were curious, so we took a closer look. Then, I felt something give way under my fingers. I whispered,

"It's a secret door..."

We stepped inside the statue and looked up. Wooden scaffolding stretched all the way up to its head.





Tia said,

"This statue of Amun is fake! It is made of clay and plaster. Look up… there are holes where the mouth and eyes are."

There was a ladder on the ground just by our feet. We heard footsteps coming closer. We had to hide quickly! We went back to the door. I pushed it and pulled it but nothing happened. It was stuck!

I looked up and said to my friend,

"Follow me!"

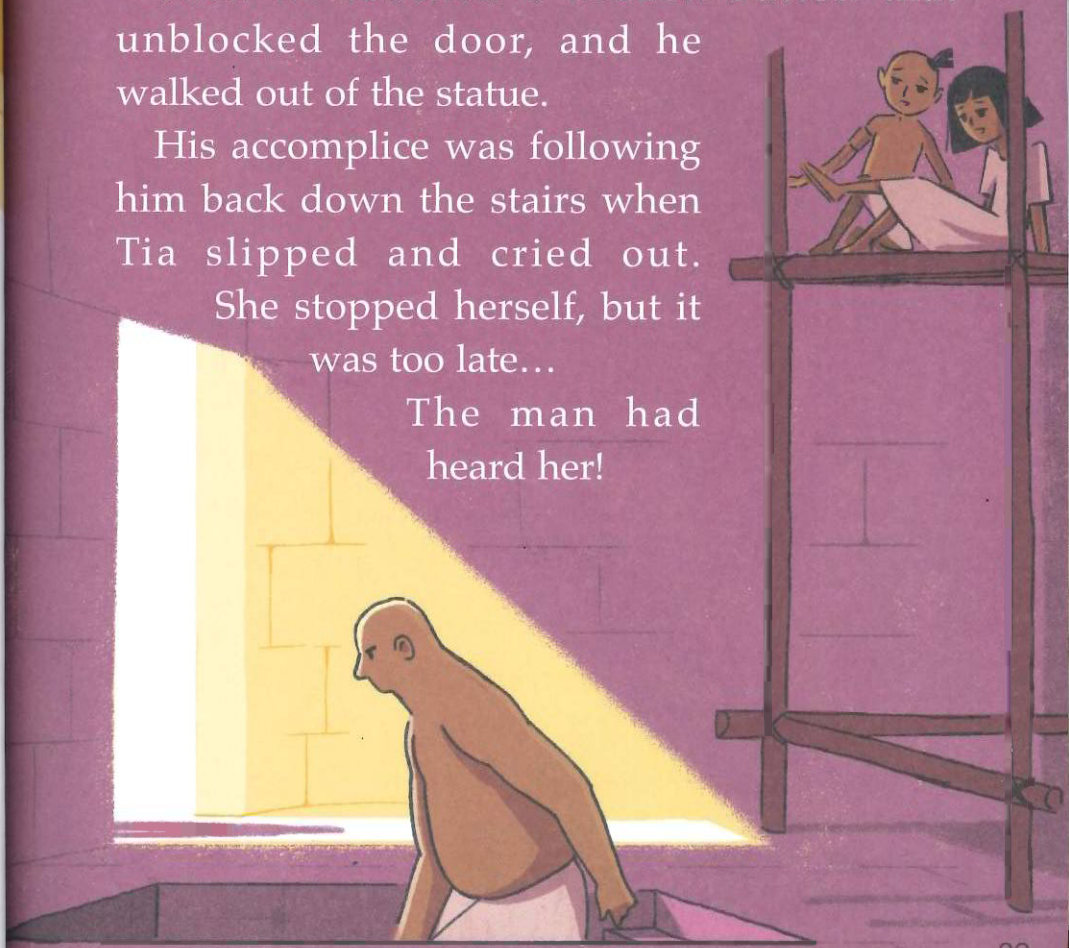
We climbed to the top of the scaffolding and then suddenly, two men appeared below us. I recognised the man with the shaved head. He said to the other man,

"Wait for my instructions."

Then he touched a hidden button that unblocked the door, and he walked out of the statue.

His accomplice was following him back down the stairs when Tia slipped and cried out. She stopped herself, but it was too late…

The man had heard her!



He quickly came back up the stairs and saw us perched above him. Fortunately, he was large and heavy. He would not dare to climb the scaffolding as it would not support his weight… He said,

"Come down. I won't hurt you."

But his smile gave me goose bumps.

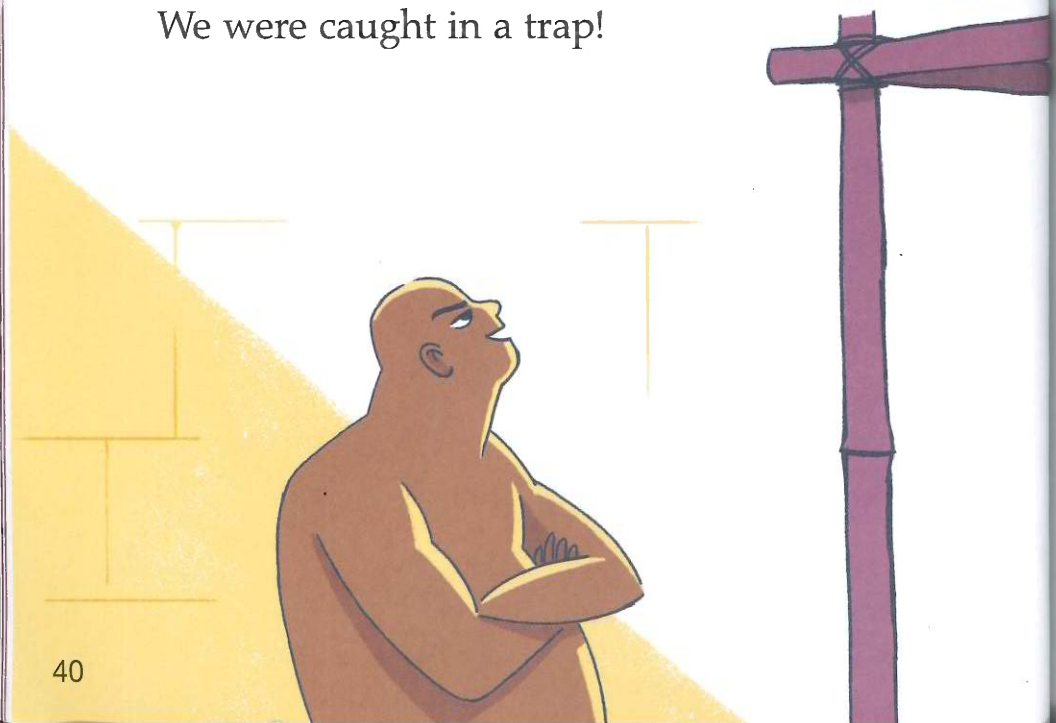
I replied,

"No way!"

The man sat on the stairs and said,

"I can stay here for as long as it takes."

We were caught in a trap!



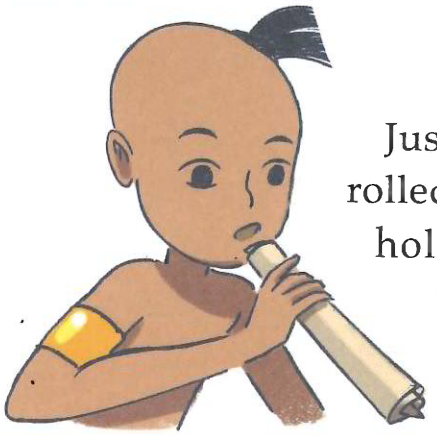
Ouni and Tia follow the man with the shaved head into a false statue of the god Amun… And they are caught in a trap!

Chapter 7



Amun's message

An hour passed, then two. It was beginning to be very hot inside the false statue… Suddenly, we heard music. The Opet festival was beginning! We climbed up the scaffolding to the openings for the eyes. From there, we could see singers and musicians parading towards us. Behind them came Pharaoh Sokar. Tia and I shouted for help but nobody heard us.

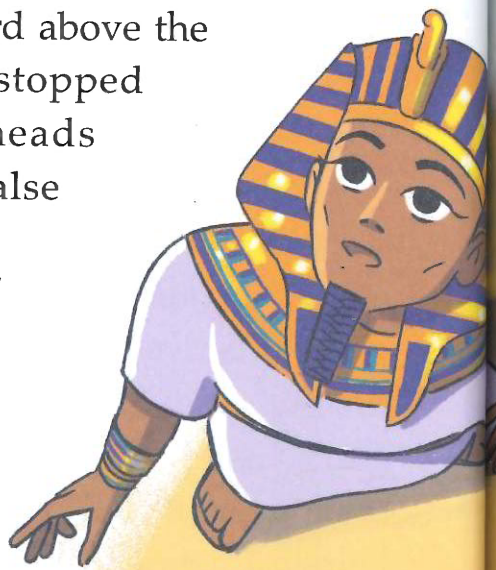


Just then, I found a sheet of rolled-up papyrus stuck in the hole of the statue's mouth. Suddenly, it all became clear! I realised how Samut had been fooled, and I decided to use the same trick to save the pharaoh! I grabbed the papyrus and used it to amplify my voice and announce,

"Pharaoh, this is Amun speaking to you!"

My voice could be heard above the procession. The music stopped immediately and all heads turned to look at the false statue. I carried on.

"Pharaoh, come closer!"



Sokar was fascinated and walked towards the statue. But a man got in his way. He had a shaved head and was wearing leopard skin, the traditional clothing of priests. I couldn't believe it... it was the plot leader that we had followed earlier! The man said to the pharaoh,

"It might be dangerous. Allow me to deal with this, your Majesty."

Sokar protested,

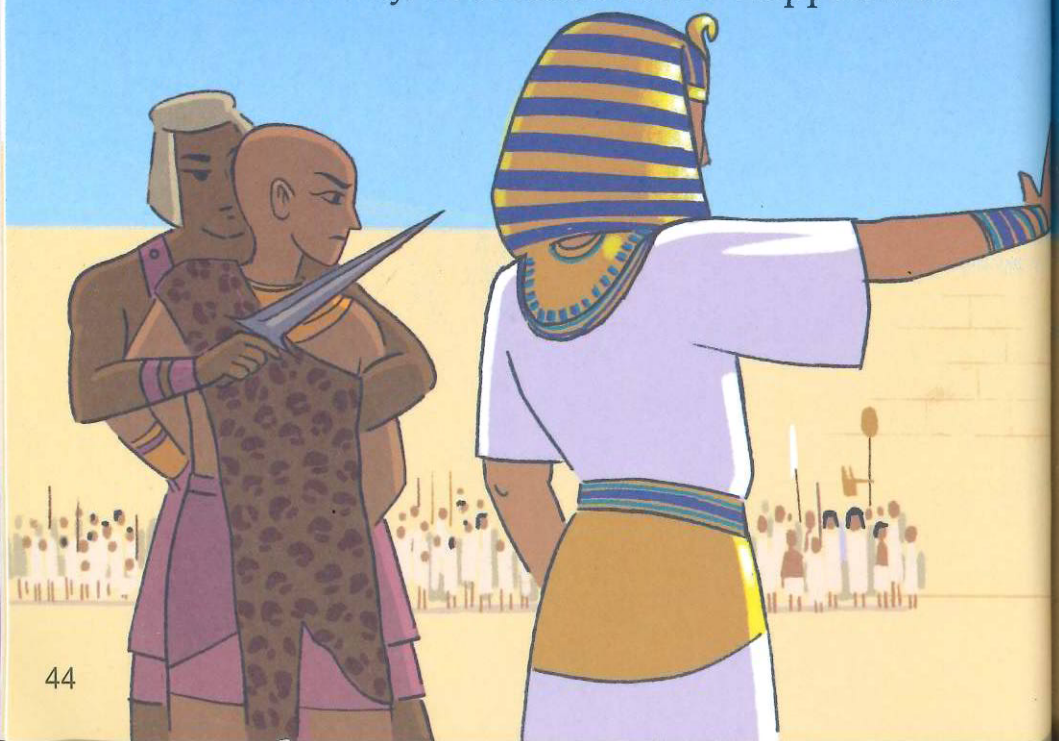
"No, my brother, I must obey my god."



My brother? So that explained everything. The man with the shaved head was Amun's high priest, and also the pharaoh's brother. The poisoned honey had come from him. As Sokar had no children, if he died, this traitor would inherit the throne! Without hesitating, I shouted through my papyrus,

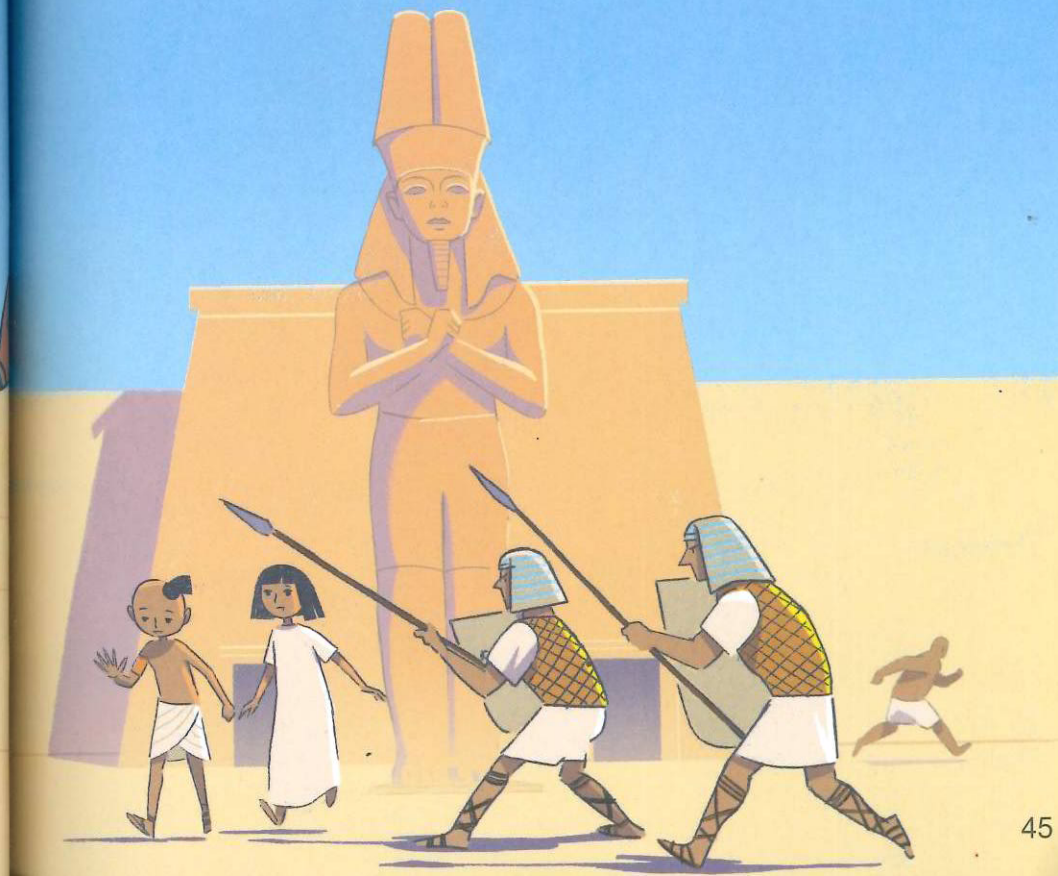
"Pharaoh, this man wants you dead. Arrest him!"

When the pharaoh's brother heard that, he tried to run away, but some soldiers stopped him.



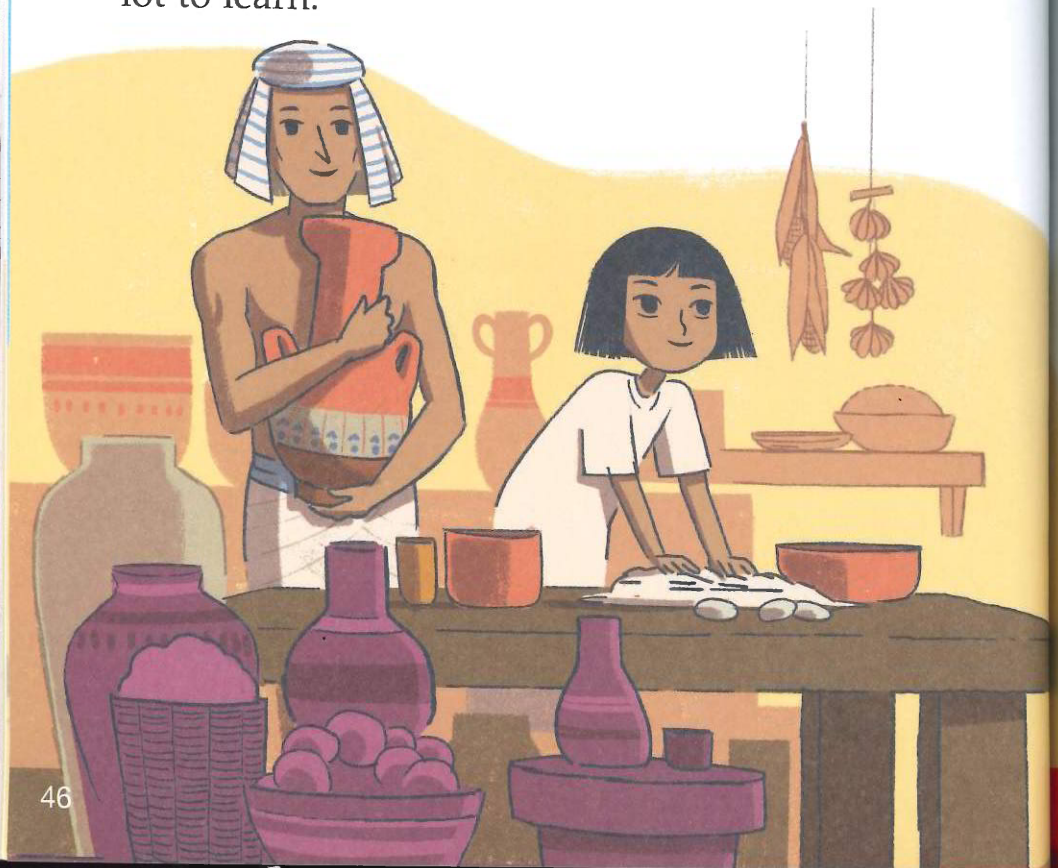
His accomplice, who was still inside the statue, realised that things were not going well and he ran away too. At last, it was safe for Tia and me to come out of the statue. When Pharaoh Sokar recognised me, he ordered his guards to let us approach him. I bowed my head and said,

"Your Majesty, I have a long story to tell you..."



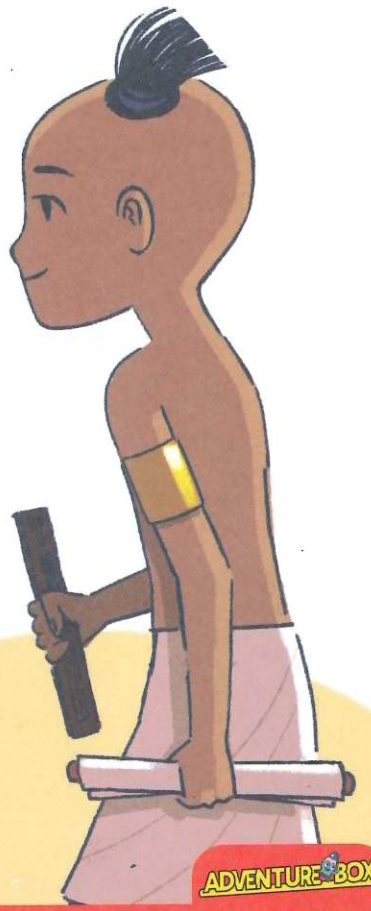
I explained to the pharaoh how Tia and I had discovered the plot against him. He put his brother in prison and got rid of Samut, the cook. My friend was rewarded when Sokar nominated her top kitchen assistant!

Everything changed for me too. I became a pupil of the royal scribe! One day, I would write messages for the pharaoh, although I still had a lot to learn.



But that day, there was a special treat for me in the kitchen because the honey sent by Amun's new high priest had just been delivered. I couldn't wait to taste it!

THE END



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ADVENTURE BOX

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